



United States
Attorney's Office
Eastern District of Michigan



Southfield Doctor Sentenced to Six Years in Prison for Illegally Prescribing More Than 200,000 Opioid pills worth more than \$5.2 million

Wednesday, September 24, 2025

For Immediate Release

U.S. Attorney's Office, Eastern District of Michigan

DETROIT –Dr. Charise Valentine, 69, of Southfield, was sentenced today to six years in prison based on her conviction following a jury trial on charges of conspiracy to unlawfully distribute prescription opioids, including Oxycodone and Oxymorphone, and 10 counts of illegal distribution of Oxycodone and Oxymorphone, United States Attorney Jerome F. Gorgon, Jr. announced.

Gorgon was joined in the announcement by Acting Special Agent in Charge Reuben Coleman, Federal Bureau of Investigation, Detroit Division, and Special Agent in Charge Mario Pinto of the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services Office of Inspector General's (HHS-OIG) Chicago Regional Office.

Valentine was sentenced by U.S. District Judge Terrence G. Berg, who presided over the trial. The charges on which she was convicted and sentenced stemmed from her role as one of two doctors at Orthopedic Medical Building who issued illegal opioid prescriptions. From November 2016 to July 2018, Valentine issued more than 3,000 prescriptions for more than 200,000 pills to supposed "patients" who did not have a legitimate medical need for the drugs. Her co-defendant, Dr. Michele Ritter, also illegally issued thousands of opioid prescriptions.

Most "patients" were brought to the clinic by "patient recruiters/marketers." Orthopedic Medical Building, a sham clinic that operated out of a warehouse in Oak Park, Michigan, was a cash-only "clinic," and charged patients \$200-500 per prescription, but did not charge anything if the patient didn't receive an opioid prescription. As is common in illegal cash-only clinics, the prices were not based on the supposed service provided, but instead based on the quantity, type, and dosage of prescription opioids that the "patient" received, usually Oxycodone 30mg or Oxymorphone 40mg, two of the most

addictive prescription opioids. These prescription drugs are also among the most highly diverted prescription opioids due to their high street value. The clinic also charged cash for the creation of fraudulent medical records for the supposed "patients."

Dr. Valentine was paid about 50% of the clinic's proceeds – more than \$500,000 in cash over about 19 months – and she was paid only if she wrote an opioid prescription to a patient, not based on any supposed "medical care." She received an envelope of thousands in cash each day she worked.

The other defendants charged in the case, including clinic operator Iris Winchester, Dr. Michele Ritter, and recruiter Joyce Robinson previously pleaded guilty and were sentenced to prison.

"Doctors take an oath to heal, not poison. As a doctor, this defendant knew better than anyone the devastating harm that opioid addiction causes to people. There is no place in our community for corrupt doctors," said Gorgon.

"Dr. Valentine's sentencing sends a clear message that the FBI will not tolerate any medical professional who stands to gain personally from abusing their position and endangering the public by illegally prescribing opioids," said Reuben Coleman, Acting Special Agent in Charge of the FBI in Michigan. "We are grateful for our strong partnership with the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services – Office of Inspector General throughout the entire investigation, and we remain in lockstep with our partners on pursuing these fraudulent medical schemes to save countless lives."

"As today's sentencing demonstrates, physicians who endanger patients and engage in the unlawful distribution of prescription opioids will be held accountable," said Special Agent in Charge Mario M. Pinto of the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services Office of Inspector General (HHS-OIG). "Our agency will continue to work in concert with our law enforcement partners to protect patients and the integrity of our federal health care programs."

This case was prosecuted by Assistant United States Attorneys Andrew J. Lievense and Wayne F. Pratt. The Eastern District of Michigan is one of the twelve districts included in the Opioid Fraud Abuse and Detection Unit, a Department of Justice initiative that uses data to target and prosecute individuals that are contributing to the nation's opioid crisis.

The case was investigated by special agents and task force officers of the Federal Bureau of Investigation and the Department of Health and Human Services-Office of the Inspector General.

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